Criminal Profiling: The Past, Present, and Future

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Criminal profiling is a process used by law enforcement to identify the characteristics and behavior patterns of a criminal offender based on the analysis of crime scenes, victimology, and other relevant information. It is a tool that has gained increasing importance in criminal investigations in recent years. Criminal profiling is vital in assisting investigators to narrow down their search for a suspect, particularly in cases where little is known about the offender. The history of criminal profiling dates to the early 20th century and has evolved significantly, with the development of new techniques and technologies. It is important to note that “by itself, a profile does not solve any crime. It is only one forensic tool of many that should be utilized in the investigation of a crime.” In this paper, I will explore a brief history of criminal profiling development along with cases and also discuss some of the controversies and criticisms surrounding the practice.

Early Developments in Criminal Profiling

Early developments in criminal profiling marked a significant step in the field of criminology. Dr. James Brussel was a psychiatrist and is considered the founding father of criminal profiling in the Criminology field. He was the first pioneer to develop profiles from psychiatric tendencies in analyzing crime scenes. In the 1950s, Brussel's work with the New York City Police Department on the "Mad Bomber" case demonstrated the potential value of criminal profiling in helping to solve crimes. The Mad Bomber case refers to a series of bombings that occurred in New York City from the 1940s to the 1950s, where a man who called himself "The Mad Bomber", George Metesky, planted bombs in public places such as movie theaters, train stations, and public restrooms. He would often send taunting letters to the police and newspapers, which included clues about his identity and motives. Dr. Brussel accurately predicted that the Bomber would be wearing a double-breasted suit by analyzing Metesky’s

psychological profile. (Boylan, 2021). This outbreaking discovery led to an evolution in investigations and had begun to open new paths in the field.

Howard Teten, an FBI agent who had a keen interest in the psychological factors that drive criminal behavior, joined the agency in 1962. By 1969, Teten was recruited by the Training Division to serve as an instructor, and within a year, he persuaded his supervisor to allow him to teach a workshop on "applied criminology." His classes quickly became popular in the field of criminology. Teten partnered with FBI New York Special Agent Patrick Mullany, who held a master's degree in educational psychology, and the two started teaching together. Teten would provide a detailed overview of a case, while Mullany would highlight how specific elements of the criminal's personality were exposed at the crime scene. Afterwards, the FBI's Behavioral Science Unit was established in 1972. The FBI established a behavioral science unit to further the concepts that Teten and Mullany had been teaching within the FBI and the law enforcement community. The unit was headed by Supervisory Special Agent Jack Kirsch and included Teten and Mullany (with Ressler joining in 1975). As the unit grew, so did their educational, research, and service responsibilities, which led to the FBI's increased study and comprehension of serial killers (FBI, 2013). Netflix, a popular streaming service, created a series called *Mind Hunters* based on the events of Teten and Mullany that lead to the creation of behavioral science.

Current Advances in Criminal Profiling

Advances in criminal profiling have continued to evolve since the early developments in the field. One major development was the creation of the FBI's The Violent Criminal Apprehension Program (ViCAP). It is a national database established by the FBI that is designed to help law enforcement agencies investigate and apprehend violent criminals. ViCAP collects information on crimes that involve murder, sexual assault, missing persons, and unidentified human remains. The database can be used to link crimes that may be related, even if they have

occurred in different jurisdictions. By using ViCAP's database, law enforcement agencies can develop comprehensive profiles of offenders and assist investigators in identifying potential suspects (FBI, 2016).

Additionally, the use of computer databases such as CODIS, in profiling DNA Fingerprinting has allowed for more efficient analysis and tracking of criminal patterns. DNA profiling can provide information about the physical characteristics of a suspect, such as their sex, eye color, and hair color. CODIS plays a significant role in criminal profiling by providing law enforcement agencies with a powerful investigative tool. DNA evidence is often left behind at crime scenes, and through CODIS, DNA profiles developed from crime scene evidence can be compared to the Convicted Offender index, containing DNA profiles of individuals convicted of violent crimes, and the Forensic Index. If a match is found, it can help identify a suspect or confirm their involvement in the crime, thus assisting law enforcement in their investigation. This technology can also link crimes together, even if they were committed years apart, by identifying the same DNA profile in multiple crime scenes. Therefore, CODIS can be a useful tool in narrowing down potential suspects and building criminal profiles based on their DNA evidence. This can help investigators create a more detailed profile of the suspect and narrow down the list of potential suspects. These advances have allowed for more effective and precise criminal investigations and have become an increasingly valuable tool in law enforcement. (Panneerchelvam & Norazmi, 2003)

High-Profile Cases and the Use of Profiling

Besides the “Mad Bomber” criminal case being one of the first for the use of criminal profiling, there are several other high-profile cases. One well-known case that utilized criminal profiling is Ted Bundy. Bundy is one of the most notorious serial killers in U.S. history, was the subject of an extensive criminal profiling investigation during his reign of terror in the 1970s.

His orderly and meticulous nature extended to both his personal life and his crimes. Criminal profilers noted that Bundy was a "five window killer," meaning he exhibited all of the typical stages that many serial killers do: fantasy, stalking, abduction, murder, and disposal. This behavior was indicative of an obsessive-compulsive personality, which is characterized by a strong need for order and control. Profilers used these insights to help law enforcement agencies track Bundy's movements and eventually capture him. His case highlights the importance of criminal profiling in identifying and apprehending dangerous offenders, as well as the value of understanding the connection between a killer's personality and their criminal behavior (Holmes, p. 45-46 2009).

Another popular criminal case that utilized profiling is Joseph Paul Franklin, a notorious killer who went on a murder spree across 11 states in the late 1970s. His crimes were not only heinous but also appeared to be racially motivated. He was a white supremacist who targeted African Americans and Jews in his shooting sprees. His racist beliefs and motivations were key in his selection of victims, and his tattoos reflected his extremist views. The FBI's behavioral analysis unit recognized this as a crucial aspect of his personality and used it to help identify and apprehend him. Ultimately, Franklin was convicted of several murders and executed in 2013. His case serves as an example of how criminal profiling can be used to identify and catch even the most elusive and dangerous offenders (FBI, 2014).

Criticisms of Criminal Profiling

Criminal profiling, despite its widespread use in law enforcement, has faced criticism from the beginning and is considered controversial. One major criticism is the lack of scientific validation for profiling techniques. “The significant differences amongst approaches to offender profiling, along with widespread disputes between practitioners, have greatly impeded the field. These limitations have caused skepticism about the investigative utility of profiling, along with

the scientific efficacy of the practice. For offender profiling to have scientific validity and more widespread recognition in investigations and admissibility in court, a uniformed approach to practice remains essential" (Petherick & Brooks, 2020).

Another issue is the potential for cognitive bias in criminal profiling. Profilers may unconsciously rely on stereotypes or preconceived notions, leading to inaccurate conclusions. One example of cognitive bias that can impact criminal profiling is the fundamental attribution error. This type of bias can lead law enforcement to concentrate on the incorrect suspect by hastily attributing someone's actions to their character or personality without considering external or situational factors that may explain the behavior. Additionally, there is a risk of false accusations based on profiling, as innocent individuals may be targeted based on perceived behavioral patterns that can lead to wrongful convictions (Madeodev, 2021).

While profiling is based on behavioral science theories and investigative experience, Holmes states "Criminal profiling is an excellent law enforcement tool. However, it is just one of many tools and does not replace good investigative techniques...By itself, a profile does not solve any crime. It is only one forensic tool of many that should be utilized in the investigation of a crime" (Holmes, 2009).

What is the Future of Criminal Profiling?

As technology continues to advance, so will the field of criminal profiling. One potential future advance is the use of machine learning and artificial intelligence algorithms to analyze vast amounts of data and identify patterns that human analysts might miss. Advancements in genetic research could lead to new insights into the biological factors that contribute to criminal behavior, potentially allowing for more accurate profiling. However, there are also potential negative impacts of technology in criminal profiling. One concern is that technology could be used to reinforce biases or to make false assumptions based on incomplete data. Additionally,

there are concerns about privacy and civil liberties, particularly as profiling techniques become more sophisticated and invasive. On the positive side, technology can provide better tools for collecting and analyzing data, which can lead to more accurate and reliable profiles (Fritsvold & Bio, 2022).

Conclusion

In conclusion, criminal profiling has come a long way since its early developments, and its effectiveness in assisting law enforcement agencies in criminal investigations has been demonstrated in several high-profile cases. Advances in technology, particularly the use of computer databases, have made it possible for law enforcement to develop comprehensive profiles of offenders and identify potential suspects. Criminal profiling is a valuable tool in law enforcement, but it is important to remember that it should be used in conjunction with other forensic tools to investigate a crime.

Controversies surrounding the practice continue to be debated in the field, but its evolution and application in solving crimes have made criminal profiling an essential tool for law enforcement investigations. Overall, criminal profiling has become increasingly vital for investigators, and as technology and techniques continue to develop, it is likely that criminal profiling will play an even greater role in solving crimes in the future.

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